

One major problem however, which is plaguing the HTML5 marketplace until now, has been the extremely slow pace of standardisation where each browser or vendor has had its own implementation of HTML5 APIs and features. There are now a lot of modern frameworks/tools available to supplement this technology and with the support of leading giants like Apple, Google, Intel, Mozilla etc., the trend for better compatibility has indeed sped up, wherein HTML5 features are much closer to a formal specification by the W3C. Keeping these developments in mind, Intel has decided to ride the bandwagon for the open web of HTML5. It has recently announced the availability of a rich set of tools including the Intel XDK, HTML5 App Porter Tool and many others. As stated earlier, it is widely accepted that the success of a platform, whether hardware or software, depends a lot on the availability of content. It is clear that Intel too is aware of this fact, and the chip manufacturer understands that it would be in its best interests to make as many apps available on their Intel based devices, as are possible.

INTRODUCING THE INTEL XDK

The Intel XDK can be best defined as a sort of cloud based IDE which supplements the HTML5 mobile app development. One of its main features is the emulation of a lot of devices for HTML5 based apps and even hybrid native apps. Some of these devices include iPhone, iPad, Samsung Galaxy S, Galaxy Tab, Microsoft Surface and ultrabooks. It supports never before heard of features in an emulator, like accelerometer emulation across all the three axes, multitouch, geolocation and allows the developer to choose the current data connection type for the emulated device. Multitouch emulation has a nice touch to it too, one can just hold the right mouse button anywhere on the emulator screen and then left click to provide multiple touch inputs. This is some of the functionality which is very well supported by hybrid HTML5 applications, which offer a good compromise of providing access to functionality like the accelerator and other sensors which are unavailable to HTML5 tools.

While an editor mode is integrated, one can very well choose to develop the app in their own IDE and upload the code here in order to test the functionality in its emulator. The editor mode also supports development of server side components and has readymade templates available for ASP and PHP.

INSTALLING THE XDK SOFTWARE

The XDK can be installed on all the three desktop platforms including Mac OS X, Windows and Linux as long as you have Google Chrome and Java installed. There is also a Google Chrome plugin available in the Chrome Web Store which provides a button to load the XDK in its Java Applet. Further links to download and install the XDK as well as the Chrome extension are available at xdk-software.intel.com.

Installation is fairly straightforward and you will see some java archives being copied for the first time, followed by which it will ask you for the location where the XDK files are to be stored. If installed and loaded successfully, you will be presented with a login screen. Assuming that you do not have an ID, you only need to provide your email address for the first time and click Submit. If the email ID is correct, you will automatically be presented with a sign up screen asking for further details which you can fill in. Once this process is completed and you are logged in, you will be presented with Intel's Hello World app. You will be able to browse and load other samples and demos bundled with the IDE.

YOUR FIRST APP

To begin creating your first application, click on the Start New button on the top left corner and you will be presented with the Set up a new HTML5 app project screen asking for project details. Fill in the name of the project, followed by the development path you'd like to follow. The development path indicates whether you'd like to build up from a pre-existing demo, use the app starter wizard or use the Game Dev Mode which integrates features for ImpactJS and Ejecta based simulation for simple and 2D physics games. Alternatively, you could choose to upload a readymade zip file containing all the HTML and javascript files for the app.

For the purposes of our demo, creating an app from the app starter wizard would be the best way to describe all the features provided by the XDK. The wizard is basically a



The navigation bar setup screen



The page setup screen